

## **A Literature Review of the Progression of Oral Histories in the Archive**

From its inception, the incorporation of oral histories into the archive has been met with much debate, leading to a plethora of back-and-forth discussion in archival literature. In its early appearances in archival literature, the use of oral history was questioned in regards to its legitimacy as a form of factual record making. The views on oral histories in archives slowly began to change with the introduction of the ‘activist archivist’ changing the landscape of discussion in literature. Decades later, the conversation has moved from debates of the merit of oral histories in archives to the discussion of oral histories in action through the lens of focusing on the process of developing case studies, many of which are happening in other literature fields like oral history and not necessarily in the archival sphere in general. Recent literature shows the way that oral history has been utilized to “fill the gap”, provide the space for marginalized voices to expand on their experiences to make themselves less static or flat characters within existing archival records, or in some cases push back on or contradict the archives depiction of them. However, the incorporation of oral history in archives is not without its complications and flaws. Literature also exists to discuss the issues that can accompany oral histories and how those issues need to be addressed to align the practice with the identified intentions of incorporating oral histories into the archival space and discussing how those identified intentions might have been a bit naïve. This literature review will chronologically follow the evolution of the role of oral history in archives to track trends and assess if and how archives have utilized oral histories to expand the voices of the narratives present in their collections.

The scholarly works used to conduct this literature review were chosen by scanning through Drexel’s online library. The initial focus was on acquiring readings with a general focus on the history and importance of oral history in the archival space. Because of the history of debate regarding this topic, a select number of readings were chosen that focused on summarizing the key points and participants. To avoid getting stuck on focusing the entirety of the literature review on the initial debate of the legitimacy of oral history as record keeping, the search had to be intentionally steered to more recently written publications to track the progression of the discussion of oral histories. This led to a natural shift in focus to case studies, the wider topic of conducting oral history research projects, and a focus on issues within the research and what still seems to be missing.

Oral history, which the University of Toronto Libraries defines as “a method of inquiry that documents memories and personal experiences of the past events through captured dialogue” (De’ath, Cline, and Taylor, 2024) acts as primary source for researchers looking to provide context to their work by incorporating the voices of those directly involved in the historical events to tell their experiences in their own words and have them documented.

The idea of the inclusion of oral history in archives is relatively recent, with it first appearing in the archival landscape in the late 1940's (De'ath, Cline, and Taylor, 2024). It mostly focused on supplementing documents of prominent figures already present in the archives.

The 1960s saw a shift in focus to the use of oral histories in archives to bolster collections and fill in gaps. This shift aligned with the change in historical literature to focus on history from the bottom up (Wagner Webster, 2016). However, the literature encouraging the use of oral histories in the archives was met with a large amount of pushback. Many scholars denounced the credibility of oral histories as unscientific and biased (Fogerty, 1983; De'ath, Cline, and Taylor, 2024; Wagner Webster, 2016). Those opposed were wary of the reliance on human memory and were offput by what they perceived as oral history projects of questionable value (Fogerty, 1983). This rebuttal to oral histories because of the fear of bringing human memory and emotion into the archive speaks to the conversation of how archives viewed themselves and their roles in history at the time. Archives thought of themselves as neutral caretakers of records focusing on truth and objectivity (Swain, 2003). "Focusing collecting endeavors on oral histories proposes a number of challenges to this archival neutrality" (De'ath, Cline, and Taylor, 2024). With the person first approaches of oral history that brought with them the challenges of dealing with narrators with biased views, archivists clinging to the idea of the archives as neutral spaces could not find value in the process of creating records to add those narratives into their archives (Swain, 2003).

The argument surrounding the place for oral histories in the archives was thrown into further disarray with the introduction of the 'activist archivist' (Wagner Webster, 2016). While the 1960s had called for a more bottom up approach in shifting the focus on whose narrative were incorporated into the archive, the 1970's concept of the 'activist archivist' openly called for archivists to make it a part of their mission to actively focus on creating or acquiring records from groups that had been underrepresented in the archives to create a more just and wholistic archival collection (Wagner Webster, 2016). With the focus on what Fogerty refers to as 'filling the gap' in archives (Fogerty, 1983), archivists were forced to step out from behind this idea of the archives as a neutral space to work towards incorporating a larger swath of voices (Swain, 2003; De'ath, Cline, and Taylor, 2024). Because the current acquisition processes had lent themselves to the existing issues of the lack of diversity within collections, new modes of acquiring documents would be needed to fill the current gaps. Thus, oral histories and their abilities to help archivists create the records needed to bring new underrepresented groups into the archives emerged as one of the best viable options, helping to move oral history further away from the idea that they lacked merit in the archival field (Wagner Webster, 2016). This shift in practice towards archivists creating

records also firmly solidified the theory that archives have power and were not and should not be seen as neutral keepers of records (Swain, 2003; De'ath, Cline, and Taylor, 2024; Dodd, 2021).

What came after the literature of the 1970s and 1980s, which focused on the merit of oral history in archives and their position in proving that archives were in fact not neutral, was mixed in topic and filled with gaps. It seems that after the merit of oral history no longer needed to be consistently proved, it fell out of favor for discussion in archival literature. It still had its naysayers, but seemed to have been integrated into the profession, making it common practice for the field (Swain, 2023). What would emerge was the mention of oral history in discussions about the digitization of archival records (Swain, 2003), and literature about the process of conducting oral history research and applying those processes as case studies (Wagner Webster, 2016). It should be noted that there is an evident lack of literature on case studies focusing both on methods, and the general role of oral history in archival literature. However, that is not the case in oral history publications (Swain, 2003; Wagner Webster, 2016).

While there is a definite lack of literature focusing on the methods used to conduct oral history research projects, and larger case studies in general, the literature that does exist is rich in information and does much to validate the idea that archives in and of themselves hold power and require untraditional forms of acquiring records, like the incorporation of oral histories, to further incorporate groups and identities that otherwise would not be properly represented. Dodd (2021) discussed the relationships of power between the archives and oral history by looking at the way archives have participated in the disappearance of childhood experiences from record through the processes of archival categorization. The idea of the archive as having power is reinforced, but Dodd (2021) clarifies that this power is not static. Rather archives and oral history have an affective relationship where the archives do shape who is approached for oral histories and establish expectations, but oral histories also contain the power to reaffirm the social constructs through which the archive can be viewed and allow for groups that have been erased to reemerge. In this case it was the addition of oral histories to existing government records of young girls in France affected by World War 2 that allowed for these girls to step out from behind their static descriptions in government records to show much fuller narratives that contextualize their experiences through the lens of childhood (Dodd, 2021). Gallwey (2013) also discussed the benefits of oral histories in archives for research surrounding the experiences of single mothers in post-World War 2 society in the United Kingdom. She uses a much more process focused approach to discuss how she utilized archived oral history material from the Millennium Memory Bank, which was a collaboration between the British Library and BBC Radio, to conduct her research by

listening to recorded interviews to get a better sense of historical situatedness and social identity. Literature existed about single motherhood at that time, but there was a lack of information about the experience of single motherhood from the mothers themselves (Gallwey, 2013). Like Dodd (2021), Gallwey (2013) emphasized the use of oral histories to foreground the voices and experiences of those who appeared in literature as subjects that were written about but not usually included in the process, by giving them the power to reemerge as fully actualized members of society able to control their own narratives. Banerjee (2021) focused on the discussion surrounding domestic violence in Bengal and looked at how archives are part of the creation of mainstream discourse that affect state policies. This mainstream discourse is challenged and countered through the inclusion of women's narratives through oral histories. The archive, which is comprised of domestic incidence reports with very rigid formats dictate the way that these women's very personal experiences are dwindled down to fit the pre-chosen categories, homogenizing domestic violence as uniform experiences that then get moved to archives that legitimize as factual these summarized experiences that have been stripped of their nuance (Banerjee, 2021). These accounts, void of these women's voices result in a very government defined idea of domestic violence that silences women by refusing them the ability to discuss their experiences on their own terms. It is through oral histories that adequate representation of the multilayered experiences of violence are captured in a way that fully shows how embedded domestic violence is in society (Banerjee, 2021). All three of these scholarly works help to situate the importance of having oral histories to accompany the preexisting records in archives to allow for underrepresented voices to take center stage in their own narrative (Dodd, 2021; Gallwey, 2013; Banerjee, 2021). The presence of oral history can help push back on what Banerjee referred to as the patriarchal relationship between archives and their records of underrepresented communities (Banerjee, 2021).

While the reviewed case studies provide great examples of the importance of oral history in the archives, they also point to issues within the practice that need to be addressed. Issues with the actual processes and methodologies used to conduct oral histories have been brought up, pointing to several flaws within the framework. Wagner Webster (2016) points to the issues surrounding acquiring funding for oral history projects, which require lots of time and resources. This issue of funding is nothing new, as Fogerty (1983) identified it as one of the setbacks of conducting oral history projects decades earlier. The issue of quality control was also mentioned several times throughout the literatures as oral history is a practice that stretches across multiple professions leading to a lack of one set standard (Fogerty, 1983; Swain, 2003; Shopes, 2015; Gallwey, 2013). Swain (2003) points to the difficulties of accessing these oral histories in archival spaces because of the way they are labeled and stored. Gallwey (2013) calls for the inclusion of

supporting documentation to assist researchers with their search process. Wagner Webster (2016) urges oral historians to publish their case studies to help bolster the literature.

Other literature highlighted issues with the theory and practice of oral history itself. What seemed to emerge throughout some of the scholarly works, especially those conducted as studies of the oral histories of specific underrepresented groups was the need to address the structures of power present in oral histories (Banerjee, 2021; Shopes, 2015; Gallwey, 2013). The literature from the 1960s, 1970s, and 1980s that focused on filling the gaps in archives readily acknowledged the ways that archives existed in positions of power, but there seems to be no thought or mention of how the practice of oral history came with its own set of power structures that needed to be addressed to ensure a fair and just representation of those providing their narratives. Early literature discussed the incorporation of oral histories into archival spaces as a sort of catch all fix for incorporating the documents and experiences of those who at the time lacked proper representation in the field. As Shopes (2015) so brilliantly put it when discussing her experiences working as an oral historian over the decades, the post 1960s rhetoric informing how oral history practitioners thought about the role of oral history and how it would affect social change was a bit naïve.

Banerjee (2021) and Shopes (2015) both mentioned these visceral moments of the recognition of power structures within oral history by including explanations of situations where they realized that as interviewers their tendency to try to fit topics into broader academic frameworks were at times contradictory to how the narrators viewed their own experiences. The assumed meanings that they were attaching to specific words within the interviews were not at all aligned with how the interviewees would define them when the interviewer took the time to ask for clarification (Banerjee, 2021; Shopes, 2015). This made it clear that if the interviewer was not careful, it was very easy for them to engage in meaning making shaped by their own personal experiences and biases that strayed from the narrator's focus and intent. Issues of authorship also arose within the drafting and publishing stage. The researchers clearly had their own objectives regarding the topics they wanted to discuss for the purpose of academic literature, which worked to shape the narrative. Gallwey (2013) mentioned how the Millenium Memory Bank's collaboration with the BBC radio meant that the interviews were overshadowed by the need to be entertaining. This meant that interviewers were instructed to conduct their interviews in ways that avoided structuring that clearly pointed to discussions on key topics like gender, class, and ethnicity. Shopes (2015) also referenced this struggle between the wanting to align the narratives with academic focuses while also honoring the stories of those interviewed. When the drafts were submitted to the interviewed community to review, the

perceptions of what the focuses should be were not aligned. This resulted in two separate publications, one more scholarly in focus to be published in academic journals, and another as a book focusing on what the community wanted to see.

The issues surrounding authorship also naturally lent themselves to discussions regarding the power dynamics surrounding accessibility and consent. Banerjee (2021) raises the question of how far consent can be stretched, especially when working with sensitive topics like domestic violence within poorly protected groups. The women interviewed all had different comfort levels surrounding how much of their story would be made accessible to the public. This was further muddled by the fact that the women being interviewed didn't have the means to access the work done around their own narratives. While getting consent is a foundational piece of oral histories, especially with the push to make oral histories available to the masses online, consent can only be fully given in situations where those interviewed understand all facets of the oral history project, from intent, to the objectives, use, and implications (De'ath, Cline, and Taylor, 2024).

Wagner Webster (2016) provides a perfect ending point for the discussion of the progression of oral histories working towards filling the gaps in archival spaces. A recent survey she conducted amongst archivists showed that they do find value in oral histories and often conduct them. However, the oral histories conducted tended to focus on professionals in certain industries, and few of those surveyed reported that they used them to record the experiences of the underrepresented. There seems to be a disconnect between the literature of the 1960s, 1970s and 1980s that touted the benefits of oral history for diversifying the archives, and the lack of actual oral history research and literature that focuses on marginalized voices, identities, and communities to fill the gap.

The scholarly works explored in this literature review highlight the evolution of the use of oral histories in the archives, focusing on the initial debate over the merits of the process and following through to show examples of what the relationship between oral histories and the archival space can look like when foregrounding voices and narratives of underrepresented communities. The literature review also identifies issues in the process of conducting oral histories along with larger issues that have become apparent with the idea of using oral archives to battle issues of institutionalized power structures. While oral history can be used to "fill the gaps" it is not in itself a catch all practice for diversifying archival collections. Archivists must be mindful of their roles of power when conducting oral history projects to properly execute the mission of disrupting institutions of power like they initially expressed in the literature of the 1960s, 1970s and 1980s.

While the literature review briefly focuses on the very large history of the evolution of oral histories in the archive, I hope to see an uptick in literature, especially in the archival

academic space. As such a broad practice, there still seems to be much more regarding the topic of oral history that can be explored in archival literature. Gallwey's (2013) article provides an interesting framework for exploring what can happen with oral history projects that have already been completed and are being housed in archives. I think literature surrounding the second use of archived oral history records to develop future research projects that are similar in topic, but slightly outside of the focus of the original researcher's study could be an interesting new frontier.

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